



Models wearing Mohanjeet's creations. What put her in the top league of designers were her creations in a freewheeling bohemian chic style

endary Parisian address and a temple to haute couture) and I saw this beautiful shop of Mohanjeet who clearly ruled the Paris fashion scene in the 1970s," says well-known fashion designer Rina Dhaka, adding that the nonagenarian is "known for many innovative ideas, and clearly did it before everyone else".

GREWAL SPREAD her wings further and expanded her offerings to Spain, Monaco and the US. She sold her designs to retail chains such as Ann Taylor and Bloomingdales, and went on to have a presence on the prominent Fifth Avenue in New York. She even had her fuchsia pink ghagra displayed on the opening pages of the US edition of *Vogue* magazine. However, all of this was not without ups and downs. Grewal herself admits to having made many mistakes as business, she says, is her Achilles heel; but her survival instincts have kept her going.

Her sense of fashion, Grewal says, resembles her life: unrestrained and free. "I never followed any rules of fashion. I made sarees that I wore with collared shirts.

Even when I was young, I would have different socks on each foot, visible under cuffed *salwars*; [I] wore abstract geometric prints and even Sikh *karas* instead of glass bangles," she says.

Grewal believes that what she creates is ultra-luxurious and is in no way inferior to French creations. She worked with rare, authentic and exclusive fabrics, and showcased a variety that could hardly be found in one small store in Paris and so she never had any discounts or sales.

Even at 92, Grewal's eyes sparkle when someone asks her what she wishes to do next—such is her passion for life and work. She still regularly climbs stairs, avoiding the elevator. To this day, she works long hours, many times into the early hours of the morning and, when in Paris, is at her store every single day.

Now she is planning a homecoming of sorts. After half a century of successfully showcasing her work on the global landscape, Grewal plans to open a store at her Delhi home. While she's excited about it, there are also other things in the Indian capital to keep her busy. For example, there's a trust she set up in Delhi some time ago that helps educate young Muslim girls. "I help her find such needy girls and the trust pays for their education. While it is small now, Mohanjeet has big plans and miles to go before she sleeps," says her friend and neighbour in Delhi, Tamanna Varma, a freelance investment consultant who helps run her trust.

The aura of her home is such that time seems to stand still as we listen to her speak with passion about her life, her story and her undying spirit to do more. This is despite the fact that we are sitting in the sweltering Delhi heat during a power outage. But our two hours are up and it's time to leave. As we part ways with a beaming Grewal, one cannot but reflect on the fact that how, despite living in Paris for over 50 years and all that she has achieved in the city of lights, love and fashion, she is truly an Indian soul, who retains her Indian passport to this day. It seems quite ironic then that Mohanjeet Grewal, despite being a true ambassador of Indian fashion globally, is still relatively unheard of in the fashion corridors of India. Her Delhi store could remedy that. **BT**

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